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## Esoteric Buddhism in Mediaeval Maritime Asia

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## Archaeological Evidence for Esoteric Buddhism in Sumatra, 7th to 13th Century

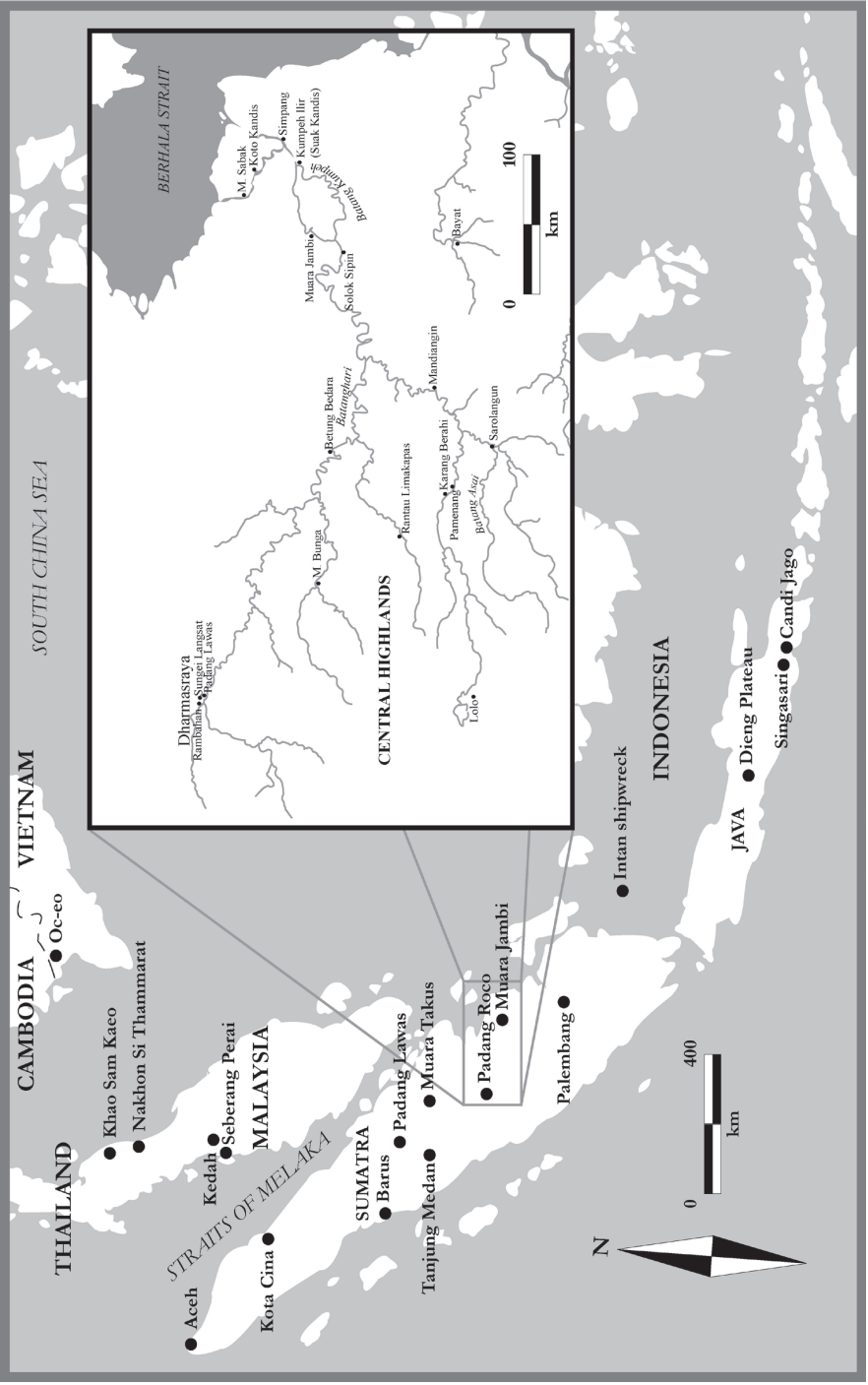
JOHN MIKSIC

RECENT ARCHAEOLOGICAL DISCOVERIES OF *vajras* and inscribed gold objects in Sumatra and under the water near the island lend support to the hypothesis that Sumatra was a significant centre of Esoteric Buddhist activity during an important phase of that religious orientation's genesis and growth. Archaeological and historical data suggest that several streams of Buddhist thought and practice coexisted in Sumatra for more than half a millennium. Geographic correlations between these artefacts and inscriptions with ethnic groups and imported items suggest that Sumatra offered fertile ground for the development of Esoteric Buddhist concepts. This chapter will summarize the archaeological correlates of Esoteric Buddhism in Sumatra from the late 7th to the end of the 13th century, and explore the implications of this data in terms of Buddhism's links to social, political, and economic variables.

Most modern Malays, even those who are highly educated, believe that their ancestors were Hindus. Archaeological data flatly contradict this assumption: they show that Buddhism was much more popular than Hinduism in Sumatra and the Malay Peninsula during the Classic period (approximately 1,000 years long, from the 4th to the 14th century AD). In Kedah, one of the bastions of the Buddhist kingdom of Śrīvijaya, an invasion by the Cōla Tamils of 1025 led to a period of Hindu domination lasting through the 11th century. The large ruin of a temple probably dedicated to Śiva at Candi Bukit Batu Pahat built during this period, and the eventual decline of Buddhism in India, may have biased public opinion. Another potentially confusing factor includes the tendency of early European scholars to label everything pre-Islamic as 'Hindu'.

Much of the art generated in the Malay realm during this period is very different from Buddhist art in modern Southeast Asia. Whereas the figure of Buddha and the *stūpa* dominate in modern Southeast Asian Buddhism, early Buddhist practice in Sumatra and the Malay Peninsula tended to favour a multiplicity of deities more reminiscent of contemporary Hinduism. The *stūpa* was present but rare in the architectural inventory. Statues of some deities associated with Hinduism have been found in Sumatra and the Siam-Malay Peninsula, but this is also true of such major Buddhist sites as Nālandā in India. Buddha did not deny the existence of Hindu gods; some Buddhists of the Classic period in India and Southeast Asia depicted Śiva as a convert to Buddha's law (see for example the *Gaṇḍavyūha* reliefs of Borobudur). Manifestations of the elephant-headed Hindu god Gaṇeśa are found in the Buddhist art of Japan, and may have existed in Southeast Asia.

The people of the Strait of Melaka during the Classical period were not passive recipients of external influences. Chinese and Indians viewed Śrīvijaya as an active participant in the evolution of Buddhist doctrines and rituals. Since George Cœdès first identified this kingdom in 1918, Śrīvijaya has been envisioned by many scholars as a major thalassocracy which dominated the Strait of Melaka from the late 7th to the late 13th century. Archaeologists and art historians have been less confident about the nature and geographical extent of the kingdom. This uncertainty stems from several factors. One factor is that the majority of the inhabitants in the kingdom's capital may have lived on water (specifically the Musi River) rather than on dry land. The second is that the art of Śrīvijaya has defied most art historians' efforts to define a particular style



Map 11.1. (© Goh Geok Yian)

associated with the kingdom (Diskul 1980). Śrīvijayan sculpture seems to blend styles from mainland Southeast Asia and India, and Śrīvijayan (Sumatran) styles may have influenced sculptors in other regions. Another reason is that very little systematic archaeology has been conducted at classical sites in the Strait of Melaka. Most Buddhist sculptures attributed to Sumatra lack provenance. We are almost helpless in the endeavour to restore the contexts from which they were ripped.

A similar lack of focus afflicts the historical record. Most contemporary references to the kingdom were written by outsiders, rather than the people of Śrīvijaya. Observers from China seem to have perceived Śrīvijaya differently from people coming from the west (i.e., Arabs, Persians, Armenians, Indians, Sinhalese). Viewed from the Indian Ocean, the most important territories of Śrīvijaya were located at the north end of the Strait of Melaka, in Kedah, southern Thailand, Aceh, and Barus. The Chinese on the other hand viewed Śrīvijaya through the lens of their proximity to southeast Sumatra, which led their observers to give particular prominence to the port of Palembang.

The exact extent of Śrīvijaya and the political and economic threads which bound its people and territory together are likely to remain permanent matters of debate. It is unlikely that we will ever attain more than a very imperfect understanding of the network of political and economic institutions which constituted Śrīvijaya.

The same blurriness of vision unfortunately applies to religion. As a result, Śrīvijaya's contributions to Buddhist theology and art are underappreciated. Religious ideas, however, unlike political or even economic concepts, tend to be expressed in material form, including buildings, sculptures, and locally written texts. Archaeological research has begun to shed some light on the development of Buddhism in the Strait of Melaka, and this field offers the best hope that new data may yet be discovered. Unfortunately, archaeological sites are being rapidly looted or destroyed—sometimes intentionally—in this region, and the window for making new discoveries is rapidly closing.

#### THE MALAYS AND THE SPREAD OF BUDDHISM

The Malay cultural realm stretches from south Thailand, down both coasts of the Strait of Melaka, to west Kalimantan (Andaya 2008). Malay culture is carried by Austronesian-speaking people who adapted to the estuaries of the equatorial zone of Southeast Asia. This type of location favoured the development of societies which were adept at managing the exchange of commodities from specialized collectors in the hinterlands and the offshore islands. Śrīvijaya was one of the most prominent of these, but we know of many others, large and small. These populations were related to those who expanded into the Indian Ocean, reaching Madagascar off the southeast coast of Africa, and at the same time discovered and settled the islands of the vast Pacific thousands of kilometres in the other direction. They were the most successful and advanced sailors of the ancient world. It was they or their near ancestors who made possible the first interaction sphere of the South China Sea, transporting Dongson bronzes from north Vietnam to eastern Indonesia (see Calò 2013). They were probably present at the first ports in the isthmian region of the Siam-Malay Peninsula, starting with Khao Sam Kaeo, where Chinese and Indian ceramics are found together.

The oldest texts composed in the Malay realm are Buddhist inscriptions found in the north-western part of Peninsular Malaysia, in Kedah and Seberang Perai (formerly known as Province Wellesley), which may date back to as early as the 5th century. When writing appeared in Sumatra, about two centuries later, the earliest texts were political documents infused with Buddhist references. Roughly ninety per cent of the artefacts of pre-Islamic religious character in the Malay realm are Buddhist. As in much of Southeast Asia, Buddhists in the Malay cultural realm coexisted with devotees of Śiva, Viṣṇu, Gaṇeśa, and Durgā. We have no reliable way of gauging the degree of devotion which the average person in the Malay realm felt for Hinduism or Buddhism, but the distribution of Buddhist sites over the Sumatran highlands as well as in the coastal zone implies that Buddhism penetrated different social strata

and various ethnographic groups to a significant degree.

The highland populations of Sumatra speak languages which are derived from the same root as Malay, but they prefer to maintain distinctive identities, calling themselves by various ethnonyms such as Toba, Karo, Minangkabau, Kerinci, Rejang, and Serawai, rather than Malay. Politically and economically, they formed symbiotic relationships with the lowland port-cities, but the highlanders retained a considerable amount of autonomy in their dealings with the lowlands (Miksic 1985, 2009). How does the nature of Sumatran Buddhism mirror this situation? Was Buddhism in the highlands a pale and generalized reflection of that found in the cosmopolitan lowland ports, or was it equally varied and complex?

In the conventional history of Sumatran Buddhism, the name Śrīvijaya shines so brightly that it tends to blot out references to the other ancient kingdoms and regions of this huge island and the Siam-Malay Peninsula. This is partly due to the frequent references to that name (or names such as Suvarṇadvīpa, Zabag, and Sanfoqi [*Sānfōqī*] which have been assumed to refer to Śrīvijaya) in Chinese and Arab texts, and partly to the importance of inscriptions found in Palembang for understanding early Southeast Asian history. Certainly the Palembang inscriptions are important, but they are few in number, and were written in a very brief period during the late 7th century. About all they tell us about religion is that some Buddhist terms which imply espousal of a certain stream of belief were integrated into public proclamations by Jayanāśa, ruler of Śrīvijaya. Tangible remains of Buddhism are scattered over the length and breadth of Sumatra, including many locations in the hinterland that were far from the trading enclaves on the estuaries visited by foreigners.

The Buddhagupta inscription and other remains in Kedah indicate that Buddhism was probably well integrated into Malay culture long before Śrīvijaya was founded (Christie 1990). Śrīvijaya was not the wellspring of Buddhism in Malay culture. No doubt Buddhism took root at different times in various locations in Sumatra and the Malay Peninsula. Mahāyāna Buddhism placed great emphasis on sutras, on texts, and on ontological disputation

and speculation. This attitude generated a stream of communication between centres where Buddhist scholar-monks congregated. These monasteries are not seldom located in areas of sparse population, but Sumatra is criss-crossed with numerous thoroughfares, both riverine and overland, along which people, ideas, and commodities have moved regularly throughout history. Buddhist sites in inland Sumatra are situated along the trade routes which early European visitors recorded when they began to penetrate the hinterland in the late 18th century. The presence of Buddhist remains at strategic locations along these routes strongly suggests that they already existed a thousand years ago.

#### THE RISE OF ŚRĪVIJAYA

The inscriptions from Palembang contain few references to Buddhist subjects, but there is enough information to conclude that the ruler of what we might for simplicity's sake call the kingdom of Śrīvijaya expressed himself in terms found in Vajrayāna Buddhism, which was differentiated from earlier Perfection Path (*pāramitāyāna*) Buddhism by its emphasis on *maṇḍalas* and recitation of mantras (Woodward 2004: 330). 'By far the most extensive text of the empire of Śrīvijaya' (de Casparis 1956: 17) appears on a stone formerly called the Telaga Batu inscription, but now referred to as Sabokingking after the place of its discovery in Palembang. The inscription is undated but is believed to be contemporary with dated inscriptions from Palembang and other locations in south Sumatra. The inscription, 'precisely the kind one would expect to find in the capital of the empire' (Wolters 1967: 209), is a long oath threatening dire penalties against traitors. Two dated inscriptions have been found near Palembang.

The text that gives the greatest insight into Śrīvijaya's religion is the Talang Tuwo inscription (AD 684). It contains a long statement of His Majesty Jayanāśa's wish that everything in a garden which he has founded, including coconuts, areca, sugar and sago palms, fruit trees, bamboo, ponds, dams, etc., contribute to the welfare of all beings. Religious aspects of the text include the wish that the thought of Bodhi will be in them, references to the



Fig. 11.1: The Kedukan Bukit stone inscription. (Photo: author)

three jewels and the diamond body (*vajrasarīra*) of the *mahāsattva*, and the concluding wish that all will attain enlightenment. Coedès argued that these concepts belonged to Vajrayāna or Mantrayāna, which rose to prominence in the northeastern region of the Indian Subcontinent not long before this date (Coedès 1930). It is more likely that the term *vajrasarīra*, which Coedès thought was clearly Tantric, means something like

‘having a physical body as diamondlike as that of a Bodhisattva such as Vajrapāṇi’.... It may be that the terms in the inscription can all be found in [various Buddhist] texts; more probably, someone with a good knowledge of Sanskrit invented paraphrases. At any rate, the inscription leaves no doubt that Perfection Path Buddhism was well established in Sumatra in the seventh century. (Woodward 2004: 335)

There are a few other scattered fragments of stones with tantalizing references to Buddhist concepts. The Bukit Seguntang inscription was found during road construction. Unfortunately we only have parts of it. One fragment has only the initial portions of twenty-one lines. Another fragment purchased later bears the word *śikṣāprajñā*. *Śikṣā* refers to mundane knowledge (including rules of discipline), which is acquired from others; *prajñā* refers to the highest intuitive wisdom, which is inseparable from the true vision of emptiness

(*śūnyatā*). The inscription may have begun with an invocation of a perfect Buddha, Mañjuśrī, or Avalokitesvara (de Casparis 1956: 11).

In addition to formal proclamations, two other types of written materials give us some insight into the religious attitudes prevalent in the lower Musi River in the 7th to 10th century. One category consists of religious objects, of bronze or clay, some in the form of miniature *stūpas* or *stūpikās*, bearing the Sanskrit *Pratītyasamutpādagāthā*, often known as the *ye dharmā* formula (sometimes styled the ‘Buddhist creed’, but this is inaccurate; see Griffiths 2011: 144–45). The other category consists of over forty small stones inscribed with the word *siddhayātra*, palaeographically dated to the 7th century, found in several districts of Palembang. The term is Sanskritic, but not specifically Buddhist. Coedès defined it as ‘a voyage or a pilgrimage in order to obtain supernatural powers’.<sup>1</sup> Another stone found in the district of Kedukan Bukit in Palembang mentions a royal pilgrimage in which the king with 1,312 soldiers went to acquire *siddhayātra* (Fig. 11.1). The word seems to have denoted ritual visits to sacred places in order to acquire spiritual power for political or military purposes. Why those locations were believed to be places where such power could be acquired is not speci-

1. For more discussion of this and related terms, and more sources, see Woodward 2004: 336, n. 14..



fied. The same practice is attested in Javanese inscriptions, where it is sometimes associated with mountain springs (de Casparis 1956: 2).

The first person known to have written the name Śrīvijaya (as Śrībhoja) was a Chinese Buddhist monk named Yijing. He recorded his travels in search of Buddhist texts. In 671 he sailed from China to Śrīvijaya on a ship belonging to Śrīvijaya's ruler. After a residence of six months there which he spent studying Sanskrit grammar, the king's ship carried him to Malayu (Jambi, in the Batanghari valley north of Palembang), where he spent two more months. Next he went to Kedah, where he remained for a few months more before the winds became favourable for his voyage to India. From Kedah he sailed direct to Nālandā, where he spent the next eighteen years.

He then took all the texts he had collected, which he stated contained 500,000 *ślokas*, and returned to Śrīvijaya via Kedah and Malayu, both of which he said had now become part of Śrīvijaya. He strongly advised future Chinese pilgrims to spend one or two years in Śrīvijaya to 'practise the proper rules' before going to India. He himself spent at least four more years in Śrīvijaya before he returned to China for good in 695. While he was in Sumatra, several other Chinese monks joined him, some of whom also spent several years there. He noted that of the seven most distinguished Buddhist teachers of his day, one, Śākyakīrti, had 'travelled all through the five countries of India in order to learn, and is at present in Śrībhoga [Śrīvijaya]' (Takakusu 1966: 184). Yijing took one of Śākyakīrti's texts to China and translated it into Chinese.

Yijing depicted Śrīvijayan Buddhism as almost identical to that of India. One practice which he observed both in India and Sumatra was the recitation of *Jātaka* stories by both monks and laypeople (Takakusu 1896: 163). He also noted several customs peculiar to Sumatran monks. One was the practice of using a cloth three or five feet long, which they carried folded over one shoulder when walking.<sup>2</sup> He said that 'whenever Indian Bhikṣus come to the islands, they cannot but smile when they see this custom' (Takakusu 1896: 111).

2. This is similar to a cloth in traditional Malay culture called a *selendang*.

Archaeological remains of Yijing's period (the late 7th century) and the next 200 years are of limited quantity in the Palembang area. This situation is partly the result of destruction of archaeological sites in the early 20th century; for instance, in 1930 the Dutch archaeologist F.D.K. Bosch (1930: 153–54) recorded that important archaeological sites such as Seguntang Hill and Candi Angsoka had been mined for bricks for a long period. This practice was still going on in 1960, when remains of a brick *stūpa* on Seguntang Hill were reported to have been found and immediately used as building material (Bronson et al. 1973: 7). At the important site of Telaga Batu, where the Sabukingking inscription was found, F.M. Schnitger (1937a: 1ff.) found 'heaps of bricks' in 1935 and 1936. Archaeologists who explored Palembang in the 1970s found it puzzling that they could find no material remains which Chinese and Arab descriptions of a wealthy kingdom in southeast Sumatra led them to expect should be found there (Bronson et al. 1973). Concentrated archaeological research since then has yielded some notable results, and enough archaeological remains have now been discovered in and around Palembang that any reasonable person would accept that Palembang was Śrīvijaya's capital from the 7th to 9th centuries (Manguin 1993); yet, no major Buddhist structures from the Śrīvijayan period have ever been discovered there.

#### UNDERWATER ARCHAEOLOGY IN INLAND SUMATRA

Much of the archaeological evidence for life in Śrīvijaya probably lies beneath the Musi River, which forms the heart of modern Palembang. The Musi River has been a major artery of commerce for over 2,000 years. It connects the sources of gold, ivory, and other tropical luxuries with the long-distance maritime trade route through the Strait of Melaka. Whereas nobility in southeast Sumatra traditionally lived on dry land, the majority of Śrīvijaya's population lived over the river. Dredging of the riverbed in the first decade of the 21st century led to the discovery of many antiquities with market value; looting of the riverbed quickly ensued. By 2014, the volume of antiqui-



Fig. 11.2: *Vajra*-bell from the Musi river region. (Photo: author)

ties reaching the market from Palembang had declined, suggesting that either all the items on the riverbed had been discovered, or that the limits of the simple technology used by the looters had been reached. Few of these finds have been recorded by scholars. Two locations on the Batang Hari, Sumatra's second-longest river, which flows from West Sumatra province through Jambi to the Strait of Melaka, have been subjected to similar treatment.

Items known to have reached the antiquities market include cylindrical amulet containers of a silvery metal, perhaps tin, meant to be suspended from strings hung around the neck, gold items such as coins, and jewellery such as rings for fingers and ears, including types known from Central Java and dated to the late 1st millennium AD. Beads of gold, glass, and stone are common finds. Religious objects included numerous items associated with Buddhism, such as bronze statues of Buddha, and examples of what appear to be stamps used to print Buddhist texts on clay. Bronze items include faces of Kāla, mirrors, and bells with *vajra* handles for use in Esoteric Buddhist rituals (Fig. 11.2). Rolled

sheets of heavy metal appear to be tin or lead votive objects inscribed with mantras. Utilitarian objects include scale weights. Imported items include a wide range of Chinese ceramics, from Tang Yue bowls through middle-Ming cobalt blue wares, and large quantities of Chinese coins of the Tang through Song dynasties (Miksic 2012).

One of the few objects to have been studied with potential to illuminate the range of Buddhist practices in the Musi River basin is a bronze base for three images (two standing, unfortunately lost, and one kneeling in the posture of a devotee), said to have been found beneath the Musi River at Palembang. It bears a dedicatory inscription. In several respects it bears comparison with an image of Lokeśvara discovered at Gunung Tua, in the Padang Lawas region (Griffiths 2011: 151).

#### SHIPWRECKS AND BUDDHISM

Marine archaeology beneath the sea lanes in the western Java Sea has yielded important data on the nature of trade in Buddhist ritual apparatus. The *Intan*, discovered in 1997 off the southeast coast of Sumatra (Flecker 2002), was a Southeast Asian ship, probably built in western Indonesia, possibly in southeast Sumatra. The bulk of the cargo consisted of tin ingots, probably from somewhere in the tin belt stretching from Bangka Island, off the mouth of the Musi River, and south Thailand. Above the ingots were Chinese ceramics. Chinese coins on board fix the probable date when the ship sank between 917 and 942 AD. The wreck also yielded Indonesian gold coins and silver ingots with Chinese characters.

Smaller items in the *Intan* site included a wide range of bronzes, possibly made in Sumatra, where the raw materials for making bronze (copper and tin) are available. Most of the bronze objects are finished artefacts, many for Buddhist rituals. These include bronze finials with loose rings that rattled (*khakkhara*), to be fastened to the heads of wooden walking staffs carried by priests (Flecker 2002).<sup>3</sup> A large group of bronze *vajras*, and small bells perhaps meant to be worn by priests,

3. For an example found in Java, see Miksic and Soekatno (1995: 143, fig. 38).





Figs. 11.3 (above) and 11.4 (right): *Vajras* from the *Intan* shipwreck. (Photos courtesy Michael Flecker)



were also recovered (Figs. 11.3, 11.4). Other components of the cargo included statues of Buddhist deities, mainly the historical Buddha Śākyamuni.

It is possible, but rather unlikely, that the Buddhist implements were being transported by a single monk, or a group of them. They seem to have come from the same part of the ship as other items of cargo. This indicates that Buddhism was sufficiently popular that an industry specializing in producing bronze items including mirrors (probably secular items) and religious paraphernalia developed, perhaps in the Palembang area. The large quantity of *vajras* compared to the other bronze items in the cargo implies that they were in high demand by Buddhist practitioners in Java and Sumatra in the mid-10th century, and that Sumatran bronze casters were well acquainted with their iconographic details.

#### THE END OF ŚRĪVIJAYA?

Chinese scribes used the transcription *Shilifóshì* (or *Shilifóshì*) to transcribe 'Śrīvijaya' until the end of the Tang dynasty in 906, most probably to refer to a polity centred at Palembang. Beginning in the early 10th century, Chinese records dropped *Shilifóshì* and a new name appeared: *Sānfóqí*.

The name Śrīvijaya had already disappeared from Southeast Asian sources; its last known use was in 775, when Face A of an inscription was carved at Ligor/Nakhon Si Thammarat in south Thailand. A Nepalese manuscript of the late 10th or early 11th century mentions an important Buddhist statue in Śrīvijayapura (Sastri 1949: 77–78). An 11th-century illuminated Sanskrit manuscript preserving a copy of an important Buddhist text,

the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*, contains depictions of famous statues and sanctuaries, three of which are found in the Malay realm: a Dīpaṅkara from Java, a Lokanātha in Kedah, and another at Śrīvijayapura in Suvarṇapura (Schoterman, this volume, p. 115 [1986: 12]). The last primary source to mention Śrīvijaya was composed in south India in 1030–31 (Coedès 1968: 142). Numerous other sources from India mention the 'Golden Island', Suvarṇadvīpa, referring to Sumatra in general, rather than Śrīvijaya. This includes a charter from mid 9th-century Nālandā, where a monastery for Sumatran monks was endowed by a Pāla king.

Chinese sources mention no missions from Śrīvijaya from 742 to 904; in that period, the only east Sumatran kingdom sending missions to China was named Jambi. In 904, the chief of the foreign quarter in Fujian was from Śrīvijaya (Wolters 1966: 226, n. 11).

Historians, notably O.W. Wolters, long persisted in translating *Sānfóqí* as 'Śrīvijaya', despite the possibility that a kingdom by this name no longer existed after the Cōla attack in 1025. Wolters (1975: 35) speculated that Jambi was the capital of *Sānfóqí*/Śrīvijaya from around 1080 until it was devastated by a Javanese attack in 1377. Eventually Wolters granted the possibility that after 1082, "Śrīwijaya" may not be the appropriate name of the overlord's center' (Wolters 1983: 51). The character *san* actually might have been meant in its literal sense, 'the Three Vijayas', denoting a new and more accurate Chinese perception of the multicentric nature of the political pattern of southeast Sumatra. The term *Sānfóqí* may have been used to refer to an area including both rival centres.

One of the implications of this historical uncertainty is that we cannot be sure whether references to the southeast Sumatra region as Sānfóqí after 904 refer to Palembang or Jambi. This ambiguity makes it impossible to connect important historical personages mentioned in foreign sources with specific archaeological sites.

#### WHERE DID ATĪŚA GO? THE RISE OF MALAYU/JAMBI

Malayu sent a mission to China in AD 644. The oldest known reference to the place named Jambi (Zhānbēi) appeared in 840, in another Chinese source (the *Youyang zazhi*). Chinese records mention two missions, in 853 and 871, from Jambi (Wolters 1967: 85). The kingdom of Malayu is thought to have been in the region of modern Jambi. Did Malayu change its name to Jambi, or was Jambi a new kingdom? We cannot tell. The gap of two centuries can however be explained by Yijing's statement that Malayu had become part of Śrīvijaya. Śrīvijaya may have monopolized communication between the Malay realm and China. The dispatch of embassies to China in 853 suggests that Malayu, now calling itself Jambi, was now free from Śrīvijaya's monopoly.

No archaeological site corresponding to the kingdom(s) which sent missions to the Tang court under the names Jambi or Malayu has yet been found in the Batanghari basin, where in later times kingdoms of those names were established. Some Buddhist images which may date from this period have been found, but no Chinese porcelain or other trade commodities from the Tang dynasty have yet been recorded there. There is a Śrīvijayan oath inscription similar to the one found on Bangka which contains the date 686 at Karang Berahi, in the Jambi hinterland. This is probably a token of subordination to Śrīvijaya. This area has not been thoroughly explored; perhaps remains from the 7th century may one day be found to explain why this location was sufficiently important that Śrīvijaya would go to the trouble of carving that inscription.

This site is situated near the junction of the Batang Merangin and several smaller tributaries. The distance from the coast is great, but near this point, the Batang Asai tributary of the Batang Hari

and the Air Kelumpang tributary of the Musi are only fifteen kilometres apart. This fact may explain why the Mahārāja of Śrīvijaya chose this site to erect an important oath of loyalty to his newly expanded kingdom of Śrīvijaya: Malayu and Śrīvijaya may have communicated via this route as well as the water trail down the Musi, up the Strait of Melaka, and then up the Batang Hari. A number of other sites with classic statues are found along the middle course of the Batanghari: Tanah Periuk, Teluk Kual, Betung Berdarah, and Marem River; settlement remains at Pamenang, Dusun Tuo Suamai, Sengkati, Rantau Kapas Tuo, and Solok; brick ruins at Teratai, Pematang Jering, and Solok Sipin; and remains of both brick structures and settlement at Danau Bangko. Remains in Jambi mainly date from the 11th through 13th centuries, when few signs of Buddhist activity have been found in Palembang. The Jambi remains are overwhelmingly Buddhist, as will be shown below.

Several Chinese sources mention Buddhism in Sānfóqí. In 1003 Sānfóqí envoys reported that their king had built a Buddhist temple to pray for the emperor, and asked for temple bells. In 1017 Sānfóqí's king sent tributes, including a letter written in gold Chinese characters and Sanskrit palm-leaf books (Groeneveldt 1960: 62–65). During this period a Chinese Buddhist, Fa-yü, met an Indian priest in Sānfóqí (Coedès 1968: 131–32). The *Song Shi* section which deals with Sānfóqí states that 'the king is styled *Zhanbi*'. It is possible that Jambi's ruler had already become the paramount ruler in southeast Sumatra at this time.

The early 11th century is a critical period in the study of Sumatran Buddhism. Suvarṇadvīpa, the 'Golden Island', had a reputation as a great centre of Buddhism. Suvarṇadvīpa is mentioned in Tibetan sources of this period such as the *Hevajratāntra* and the *Yogaratanmālā* (Schoterman this volume, pp. 115–16 [1986: 13]). According to a 16th-century Tibetan history of Buddhism, a monk named Dharma-pāla, who served as chief abbot of Nālandā in the early 7th century, retired just before Xuanzang arrived. He then departed for Suvarṇadvīpa where he undertook further study, remaining there until he died (ibid.: 113 [1986: 6]). He was one of a number of senior Indian monks from Nālandā who went to Suvarṇadvīpa.

In the late 10th century a king of Suvarṇadvīpa found a Buddha image in the ground, whereupon the people reaped a rich harvest, and converted to Buddhism. His son the prince made a pilgrimage to Bodhi Gayā, where he stayed for seven years and was nurtured by a great teacher. The prince changed his name to Dharmakīrti, and eventually returned to Sumatra to teach. According to a Tibetan source, several students went to Suvarṇadvīpa to study with Dharmakīrti. One of these was the Indian monk Candragarbha (986–1054), who was renamed Dipaṅkaraśrījñāna when he entered the monkhood, and later received the title Atiśa after initiation into an Esoteric Buddhist order. Atiśa, then aged 26, went to Śrīvijayanagara, which he described as being in Malayagiri in Suvarṇadvīpa, to study *tantra* with Dharmakīrti (or Dharmapāla) from 1012 until 1024 (Skilling 1997: 187; Bimalendra Kumar 2008: 103; B.B. Kumar 2008: 185). In 1025, which is perhaps not coincidentally the year when the Cōlas invaded the Strait of Melaka, he returned to Bengal and became head of a monastery there. In 1040 he accepted an invitation to move to Tibet, and after fourteen years he died at Netang, sixteen kilometres from Lhasa (Schoterman this volume, p. 116 [1986: 14–15]). There is therefore reason to believe that when Atiśa went to Tibet in order to ‘purify’ Buddhism according to Tibetan sources, he replicated much of what he was taught in Sumatra. Sources depict him as discussing ways of meditating in buildings constructed as multi-storey *maṇḍalas*.

Other scholars have debated the possibility that concepts regarding *maṇḍalas* which Atiśa espoused while in Tibet were first formulated in Sumatra. The remains of a monastery at Tabo, Spiti, Himachal Pradesh, contain murals which are closely parallel to those at Borobudur. Atiśa visited Tabo in 1042, and may have been present at its founding. This too may be evidence of the transmission of Buddhist ideas from Indonesia to India (Wayman 1981: 140–42; Nihom 1994: 72, n. 192.)

Atiśa is credited with the authorship of over 200 works, including a commentary on the *Kālacakra* *tantra*. His teachings were based on the Yogācāra and Madhyāmika systems, but also on Vajrayāna Buddhism (Banerjee 1984: 30, 50, 61, 74). He was considered to be an incarnation of the

Bodhisattva of wisdom, Mañjuśrī (ibid.: 51). The central Tibetan monastery of Reting is believed to contain relics of three people: Atiśa himself, his principal Tibetan student ‘Brom ston, and his teacher, ‘the Guru from Golden Island’, whose epithet is almost certainly a reference to Sumatra (Schoterman this volume, p. 120 [1986: 28–29]).

Atiśa translated a work by Dharmakīrti, *Durbodhāloka*, into Tibetan. This translation in Tibetan is the only known surviving example of Śrīvijayan literature, and one of the oldest in all of Southeast Asia (Skilling 1997). This work is a commentary on the *Abhisamayālaṅkāra*, ‘Ornament of Realization’, which in turn is an explication of the *Prajñāpāramitā*, ‘Perfection of Wisdom’. The text contains the information that the original text of the *Durbodhāloka* was composed in the tenth year of the reign of King Cūḍāmaṇivarman in Śrīvijayapura (or Śrīvijayanagara; ‘Tibetan *grong* can stand for *nagara* as well as *pura* of Suvarṇadvīpa’, Skilling 1997: 194, n. 12). He died between 1005 and 1008. Chinese and Cōla sources mention him (Coedès 1968: 141–42). Some texts add the detail that he died in Malayagiri or Malaya, which could be taken as a reference to Malayu/Jambi; Skilling (1997: 193, n. 8) suspects that ‘the extra detail comes from a catalogue of the Tanjur’.

Skilling (1997; see also Wheatley 1983: 267) equates Suvarṇadvīpa with Suvarṇabhūmi, which he identifies with the Malay Peninsula. Indian sources are certainly vague and imprecise in their use of these terms, both signifying an association with gold. Skilling goes on to assert that King Cūḍāmaṇivarman and his successor ruled from Kedah. This is possible; I have argued that for the people coming from the Indian Ocean, the ruler of Kedah was seen as more important than that of Palembang (Miksic 1995). I do not however believe that references to the ‘Lord of Śrīvijaya’ denote the ruler of Kedah. Rulership of Kaḍāra, Kiḍāra, Kataha, Kaḍāram, etc., was probably a glorious title in itself. Arguments for locating Śrīvijaya in Kedah or south Thailand are still in circulation, but the inscriptional evidence, combined with the archaeological research of Soeroso and Pierre-Yves Manguin (see Manguin 1993) in South Sumatra, is in my opinion conclusive that Śrīvijaya meant Palembang. I do however concur with Skilling (1997: 191) that ‘as

accepted by Coedès (1934: 63; 1968: 320–21, n. 176) there is no proven link between the earlier name Shih-li-fo-shih and San-fo-ch'i'. Sānfóqí could include Kedah. I will however advance reasons to believe that Malayu was the most important Buddhist centre in the Strait of Melaka between 1025 and 1200, and that Atiśa may have spent his time in Malayu/Jambi rather than in Kedah. As for Suvarṇadvīpa, the territory encompassed by this name cannot be narrowed any further than 'Sumatra'. It could mean either Palembang or Jambi, but probably not Kedah. Skilling (1997: 191) notes that 'three other works translated or written by Atiśa are associated in their colophons not with Śrīvijaya as such but with Suvarṇadvīpa (Eimer 1981: 73–78). The evidence of these colophons is ambiguous, and raises more questions than it answers'. One hopes that Skilling will return to this subject in future.

According to Skilling (1997: 188), 'the composition of *Durbodhāloka* presupposes the existence and study in Śrīvijaya of the abstruse Prajñāpāramitā and Abhisamayālaṅkāra literature; of a high level of scholarship; and of royal sponsorship'. It also implies a major Buddhist institution of learning existed somewhere in east Sumatra at the beginning of the 11th century. The only viable candidate for this role from an archaeological point of view is located at the site of Muara Jambi and its environs along the Batang Hari river, in the eastern coastal plain of Sumatra.

#### MUARA JAMBI ARCHAEOLOGY

The National Center for Archaeological Research and Development of Indonesia has identified at least twenty-six sites from the early historic period along the 800-kilometre-long Batang Hari. In addition to sites along the upper course of the Batang Hari, there are at least fifteen sites with remains of ancient settlement in the lower 120 kilometres of the river, some of which also have yielded brick ruins.

By far the most significant site is Muara Jambi, 40 kilometres downstream from the modern city of Jambi. It covers over 2,000 hectares of land along a 7-kilometre-long section of a natural levee on the left (north) bank of the river. The eastern coastal plain of Sumatra is so flat that the river is still tidal

at this point, so that it could technically be called an estuarine rather than riverine site.

Muara Jambi consists of eight principal brick temples of the 9th to 13th centuries, as well as perhaps a hundred mounds called *menapo*; water features including a large pool and man-made canals, as well as probable alterations of natural streams; and surface scatters of bricks and ceramics. Some of the *menapo* have been excavated and found to contain brick ruins. In some cases they are surrounded by artificial moats. Two more complexes of brick ruins (called Candi Teluk I and II) and *menapo* lie on the right (south) bank of the river opposite the downstream end of Muara Jambi (Eka Asih P. Taim 2013).

A small stream called the Malayu River flows north from the levee, then west, then north again, then eventually south to the Seno River, an artificial channel south of Kedaton. The upper portion of the Malayu roughly divides Muara Jambi into two sectors of unequal length: an upstream or western sector about 5 kilometres long, and a downstream or eastern sector about 2 kilometres long. Major sites in the western sector include Gedong I, Gedong II, Kedaton, and Mahligai. They are scattered over a large area. Major sites in the eastern sector include Tinggi, Kembar Batu, Astana, and Gumpung, the most important site yet investigated archaeologically. These sites all lie in close proximity to one another, and are associated with the largest artificial water feature, a rectangular pond called King's Pool (Telaga Raja).

In 2008 the Indonesian National Research Center for Archaeology undertook excavations at Menapo Adam, one of a cluster of *menapo* 30 metres northeast of Astana. Results included high-quality ceramics, both Chinese and Fine Paste Ware made somewhere in Southeast Asia, probably southern Thailand, and a large quantity of bronze nails and a star-shaped ornament with a hole in the centre; it was probably meant to be fastened to a wooden structure.

One of the most important sets of data for the history of Sumatran Buddhism was recovered from one of the sites at Muara Jambi: a large brick ruin called Candi Gumpung. This site was reconstructed in the early 1980s. The work was mainly conducted by technicians rather than archaeologists.



During the dismantling of the original structure, eleven 'holes' in the base of the temple foot were found to contain ritual deposits comprising cups of gold, silver, and bronze, small gold plates, some without inscriptions, gold lotus flowers, semi-precious stones, and crushed lead plates which were described in the reports as 'ash'. At an academic workshop held in 1985, an important paper was presented on the 'ritual deposits' recorded from this site (Boechari 1985). Boechari concluded that these deposits were supposed to replicate a Vajradhātumaṇḍala, which would have required seventeen holes.

The inscriptions enabled Boechari to identify twenty-two deities, all but one including the element Vajra. The Vajradhātumaṇḍala has thirty-seven deities; perhaps seventeen of the names found at Candi Gumpung belong to this group. However, the five Tathāgatas (Vairocana, Akṣobhya, Ratnasambhava, Amitābha, and Amoghasiddhi) are missing; only the Vajrabodhisattvas for Akṣobhya and Amoghasiddhi and two of the four Vajrabodhisattvas of Ratnasambhava and Amitābha were represented. Only three of the four doorkeepers and two of the twelve Vajratārās were found. They may have once been present, but as Boechari notes (1985: 37), 'apparently the recording of the finds by the technicians in charge of the demolition of the temple was not accurate, causing the loss of some of the inscribed gold plates'. Inscribed bricks were found, but their precise location in the temple was not recorded. At least two different types of script were used: standard Kawi, probably dating from the mid 9th to early 10th centuries (de Casparis 1975), and a squarish form resembling East Javanese script of the 11th to 12th centuries. Sherds of Chinese porcelain, mostly from the Song dynasty, were found in the compound, but their find-spots were not recorded.

It is unfortunate that no proper archaeological research was performed at Candi Gumpung. Now it will never be known whether the deviations between the finds and textual prescriptions are due to intention, and how much to chance. These discoveries have been subjected to some important analysis by learned scholars, but their conclusions are limited by the quality of the data.

In an important study, Max Nihom (1998a: 245–46) concluded that

no clear textual trace of this historically important maṇḍala [i.e. the *Vajraśekharaṇṭra*] is to be found in Indonesia and that, in consequence, the syncretic maṇḍalas of the *yogatantras* such as the *Sakalajagadvinaya*, *Sarvadurgatipariśodhana* and *Trilokavijaya* which may be shown to be extant in the Archipelago are chronologically prior to the Vajradhātu, which is orthodox insofar as it is inhabited by Buddhist divinities alone. That is, the *yogatantra* maṇḍalas populated by both 'Hindu' and 'Buddhist' divinities are necessarily earlier than the Vajradhātumaṇḍala which, the *Tattvasaṃgraha* explicitly holds, the other maṇḍalas reflect.

Thus, the syncretic features of Indonesia's cultures are not necessarily of indigenous origin. The primary influence of Tantric Buddhism in Indonesia must have occurred before the compilation of the *Tattvasaṃgraha*, the fundamental text of the *Yogatantras*, in India; this influence must have arrived before AD 700. The textual source of the Gumpung maṇḍala is probably from material also found in the *Vajraśekharaṇṭra*, which was probably found in Indonesia in a very different form to that found in the extant Tibetan canon.

Nihom found the nearest textual source for the Gumpung maṇḍala in the *Trailokyavijayamahāmaṇḍala* as described in the *Vajraśekharaṇṭra*. Internal evidence led him to the inference that the Indonesian version was older than the Tibetan version (Nihom 1998a: 249). The important—albeit tentative—conclusion he derived was that Indian Buddhist influence in Indonesia between the early 8th and 13th century 'was at best modest, and perhaps even substantially non-existent'. The lack of evidence for Tantric Buddhist influence from India after the syncretic *Yogatantra* maṇḍalas were introduced may indicate 'either an abatement of contacts between the Subcontinent and the Archipelago or a socio-economic shift in the status of Tantric Buddhism in India itself, which was subsequently reflected in the nature and/or patterns of trade with what is now Indonesia' (Nihom 1998a: 252).

In 2004, Hiram Woodward returned to the Gumpung ritual deposits in the context of a discussion of Esoteric Buddhism in Southeast Asia as a whole. He used the data from Jambi in conjunction with collections of bronze statues



from approximately the same period found in East Java to test hypotheses about the knowledge of Mantrayāna and more advanced texts in Java, and whether they were transmitted from Northern India or Sri Lanka. One collection found at Nganjuk in 1913 portrays deities ascribable to the Vajradhātumaṇḍala as described in 8th-century texts. A second collection found at Surocolo in 1976 contains twenty-two statues which seem to belong to two *maṇḍalas*: the Vajradhātumaṇḍala plus a *maṇḍala* of Hevajra (Woodward 2004: 344). Was the *Hevajratāntra*, 'a fundamental Yoginī *tantra*', known to the 8th-century Buddhists of Java? Perhaps it appeared in Indonesia in the early 11th century, around the time of Atiśa. It is known that he was familiar with the *Hevajratāntra*; he may have either taken it to Sumatra, or been induced to go there because the *Hevajratāntra* was being explored by Sumatran Buddhist intellectuals (Woodward 2004: 345).<sup>4</sup>

Woodward (2004: 346) is willing to consider the possibility that Indonesian Buddhists developed ideas which made their way to India, rather than being merely passive recipients of thoughts originating from elsewhere. One possible instance he cites is a verse from the *Bhadracarī* found on a small stone *stūpa* at Nālandā dated to the 9th century. This is the general period when the Pāla king Devapāla endowed a monastery for the monks from Suvarṇadvīpa, specifically connected with King Bālaputra, whose ancestors had probably ruled in Java. It is also the time when the long series of reliefs illustrating this text were carved on the walls of the highest terrace at Borobudur. It is possible that the *Bhadracarī* was already well known in Nālandā, but the Javanese representation indicates that it occupied special prominence there (Woodward 1990; Schopen 1989).

A second instance concerns Atiśa, who as Woodward notes spent more than a decade in 'Śrīvijaya', which might be Palembang, Kedah, or Jambi. It is known that Atiśa found texts in Sumatra which he

took back to India, and then carried even further to Tibet. Tibetan tradition holds that Atiśa and his teacher Dharmakīrti of Suvarṇadvīpa were devoted to the goddess Tārā. It has also been argued that Atiśa acquired concepts regarding inner and outer *maṇḍalas* in Śrīvijaya, but Max Nihom has disputed this (Woodward 2004: 347, n. 53). Woodward (2004: 347) speculates that the mantra *om maṇi padme hum* which is popular in Tibet may also owe its origin to Atiśa's years in Śrīvijaya.

As Woodward (2004: 330) shows, Tantric teachings evolved in two historical contexts. He uses the term Mantrayāna to refer to institutional esoterism, which arose within monasteries, and represented a new development from earlier *pāramitāyāna* or 'perfection path' Buddhism through its emphasis on *maṇḍalas* and mantras. He uses the term Yoginī Tantra for 'siddha esoterism', which arose from marginal antinomian practitioners and shared features with Śaiva and Śākta Tantric cults, including union with female partners. The chief deities of *maṇḍalas* are male gods, 'but one could also argue that the males are only conduits for the transcendental wisdom of the females' (Woodward 2004: 330). In his article, written as an extended review of Ronald M. Davidson's book *Indian Esoteric Buddhism: A Social History of the Tantric Movement* (2002), Woodward notes that in 6th-century India, kingdoms formed political structures modelled on *maṇḍala* symbolism. Female involvement associated with *pāramitāyāna* Buddhism was de-emphasised in the new structures. Either because of, or in tandem with, the male-oriented Mantrayāna, the *siddhas*, saints or perfected ones, possessors of supernatural powers (*siddhi*) arose as socio-political alternatives to increasing centralization. By AD 1000, *siddha* texts came to be accepted as Buddhist scripture.

The political advantages of playing the role of an overlord (*rājādhirāja*) of a circle of vassals (*sāman-ta-maṇḍala*) was not lost on Indian abbots (Woodward 2004: 353; citing Davidson 2002: 106), or on Sumatran chiefs. The Sabukingking inscription contains the term *sakalamaṇḍala* ('all the *maṇḍalas*'), but whether one can infer that King Jayanāśa was attempting to manipulate the symbolism of the Vajradhātu for political ends is uncertain. Woodward himself feels that 'the term [*maṇḍala*] has become so overworked in Southeast Asian histori-

4. Recent studies on images of frightful Buddhist deities from Padang Lawas (Bautze-Picron 2014) and Sanskrit inscriptions recording exact parallels to the *Hevajratāntra* (Griffiths 2014: 18–22) suggest that the cult of Hevajra enjoyed a certain popularity in Sumatra from the 11th to the 13th century.

ography and has become so imprecise in meaning that it might best be avoided' (Woodward 2004: 353). The author of this chapter, it must be declared, was a student of O.W. Wolters, whose book *History, Culture, and Region in Southeast Asian Perspectives* (1999) thrust the term squarely into the forefront of discussions about early Southeast Asian polities.<sup>5</sup> The resonance which Wolters' explication of the term has achieved over the last three decades, and the controversies which his work has incited, would seem to be good reasons to continue to explore the advantages and weaknesses of this line of enquiry.

Woodward observes that the extension of Davidson's analysis to incorporate Southeast Asian data contradicts some of the latter's conclusions. Davidson argued that Mantrayāna's rise in India was due to 'the loss of mercantile support and the rise in official patronage' (82–83, 167) (Woodward 2004: 353, citing Davidson 2002), but this model would seem to neglect the importance of the communication between Java, Sumatra, Bengal, Nākapattinam, and Sri Lanka, as well as the Pyu of Myanmar, which flourished due to expanding commerce, with religion following rather than leading the way.

Woodward believes that Indonesia and India remained equal partners in Buddhist development until about AD 900. This date is correlated with the rise of Hindu Angkor and the collapse of Central Javanese civilization. However, the examples of Indian savants who visited Sumatra, and in the case of Aśiśa went on to expand Buddhism's sphere, suggests otherwise.

In addition to the finds at Gumpung, other related items have been discovered at other sites in the Muara Jambi area. Two have been recovered from Tinggi temple, which lies in the same eastern complex. One, found in a subsidiary shrine of the main temple, bears 'the *ye dharmā* formula in curiously amputated form ... extraordinarily corrupt' (Griffiths 2011: 150). Palaeographically its script, which resembles eastern Indian Nāgarī, can be dated to approximately the 11th century. In addition to the writing, the plaque is decorated with two *vajras* which Griffiths compares with other gold plaques from Tandihet and Aek Sangkilon,

Padang Lawas (see further below). Another plaque was found in the east gateway of the main temple at Tinggi. It is related to the first, but 'it represents less than a quarter of that formula, and the remainder of the inscription clearly does not belong to any known version of the formula' (Griffiths 2011: 162).

Gedong I, also located in the same eastern complex of Muara Jambi, yielded a plaque of quite unique form: it consists of two halves, each half composed of a different metal (probably gold and silver). It was found in the fourth course of bricks on the north side (presumably of the wall; whether it was near the entrance is not mentioned). It comprises mantras resembling those connected with Mahāpratisarā, a Buddhist goddess of protection, including the goddess' name, but with fundamental differences which cast doubt on the identity of the exact text used for the composition (Griffiths 2011: 163–64).

#### PADANG LAWAS

It is not surprising to discover a site so rich in Buddhist materials as Muara Jambi in a lowland estuary easily accessible from the major maritime thoroughfare through the Straits of Melaka, along which many Buddhist pilgrims passed on their way to and from the important sites in China, India, and Java. Padang Lawas is quite a different type of site. It lies far up two medium-sized rivers, the Barumun and Panai. The name 'Pannai' appears in the list of places raided by the south Indian Cōlas in AD 1025, and also in the 14th-century Javanese poem *Deśavarṇana* (Wolters 1967: 193), but no sites of ports or other important early remains have been found in its lower course. Bosch (1930: 147–48) thought the name might have been derived from the Tamil word for 'colony'. This region (the name means 'broad plain') lies on the eastern fringe of the Barisan mountain range which separates the east coast of Sumatra from the west. Its location has one strategic benefit: it lies at the eastern entrance to the easiest pass between east and west in the entire chain (Miksic 1980). On this plain, which covers about 1,500 square kilometres, are at least twenty-six ruined brick temples and temple complexes, almost all Buddhist.

5. For divergent views, see Kulke (1993); Christie (1990b).

Padang Lawas is unlikely to have supported a large agrarian population: dry winds from the west coast blow through the pass and sweep across the plain, creating an unusually barren landscape (Mohr 1944: 538; Verstappen 1973: 11). A British traveller in 1849 was struck by the strangeness of the place on an island largely blanketed by tropical rainforest:

We have ascended Gunung Tua and cast our eye downwards from the summit Sipolpal. There we see unrolled a plain without horizon and without variety; an unbounded carpet on which the more or less luxuriant growth of the *alang* makes the only diversity and on which not a single living creature appears to move, where a tree is literally a rarity and has the appearance of stunted dwarfishness, where at a distance of miles, we descrie like an oasis in the desert an insignificant thicket, or a small strip of brushwood along the banks of a marsh or stream; where a fell scorching wind blows for months together and from the numerous conflagrations of *alang* generally spreads a dull glow through which the sunlight scarcely forces itself wavering and heavy—in a word where all nature appears to have gone to an eternal sleep. Such is the appearance of Padang Lawas.... (Willer 1849: 367)

Little systematic archaeology was conducted in the region until a Franco-Indonesian team began excavations there in 2006 (Perret et al. 2007). The earliest dated object from Padang Lawas is a bronze statue of the Lokanātha with an inscription containing the date 1039. The inscription contains a Malay word which probably indicates that the statue was made locally (Bosch 1930: 144). Nine other inscriptions from the region are known at present. One of them is dated 1179 (Tandihet I). Another, from Porlak Dolok, which records a donation from a *senapati*, is unusual because it uses both Sumatran and Tamil scripts and languages. Bosch (1930: 147) read the date as 1245, but another date in the 13th century is possible (Perret et al. 2007: 54). Although the use of Tamil language and script in one inscription is evidence for connections with South India, there are even better grounds for emphasizing the probability of links to Sri Lanka (Miksic 2004b: 207; Schnitger 1936: 6). The date on another inscription has been read as 1372 (Bosch



Fig. 11.5: *Vajra*-base at Si Joreng Blangah. (Photo: author)

1930: 147; Schnitger 1936: 13). Other undated inscriptions have been attributed to the 13th–14th centuries (Tandihet II) and the 12th–14th centuries (Bahal I; Perret et al. 2007: 54–55).

Estimates for the dates of the temples on stylistic grounds vary. Bosch (1930: 147) assigned them to the late 13th and early 14th centuries. Schnitger (1936) and Bernet Kempers (1959: 75–76) placed them earlier, i.e. in the 12th–13th centuries. I (Miksic 2004a: 207) have speculated that they may be even earlier, i.e. 11th to 13th centuries. The excavations at Si Pamutung in 2006 yielded more precise evidence for dating that particular site. Imported ceramics indicate that occupation began in the 10th century, increased in the 11th and 12th centuries, and then declined until the site was abandoned in the early 14th century (Perret et al. 2007: 70).

The architectural motifs from Padang Lawas are closely identified with Buddhism: *stūpas*, garlands, *chattras*, and *vajra* motifs (Perret 2007: 62; see Fig. 11.5). Architectural elements found at ten sites have been identified as *stambhas* (Perret et al. 2007: 67), but Ślaczka (2007) gives good reasons for considering them *stūpas*. Three possible Hindu images have been found (if one includes a four-armed Gaṇeśa), but statuary recovered from Padang Lawas is overwhelmingly Buddhist. In addition to images of Buddha, Amitābha, Ratnasambhava or Akṣobhya and Amoghasiddhi, the inventory includes a rare image of the deity Heruka.

The gold plaque from Tandihet II with eight lines in Nāgarī with a *vajra* (paleoepigraphically dated to the 13th–14th centuries) and a rectangular gold plate from Aek Sangkilon, also inscribed with Nāgarī script, Sanskrit language, with a *vajra* (Perret et

al. 2007: 54–55) were collected by F.M. Schnitger, who did not provide much contextual information. The gold plate from Aek Sangkilon was found in the main room of the temple, and has a double *vajra* in the centre and the letters HŪṂ, with seven lines of Nāgarī script which Bosch found similar to Muara Takus (Ślaczka 2007: 364; Ijzerman 1891: 59; see further below). They are reminiscent of the ‘ritual deposits’ from Muara Jambi. The possibility of a direct connection between the two sites is strengthened by the discovery of orange *kendis* (*gargoulette*) very similar to those probably made at Muara Jambi (Perret et al. 2007: 65). Perhaps Jambi provided Padang Lawas with earthenware.

#### PADANG ROCO

Another complex of brick sanctuaries deep in the Sumatran hinterland has been under study by Indonesian archaeologists since 1991. The area where the Pingian joins the Batang Hari, including Padang Roco (literally ‘statue field’) and nearby sites such as Pulau Sawah and Sungai Langsat, seven kilometres away, has long been known to be important; two large statues were found here during the early 20th century: an Amoghapāśa from Rambahan with inscriptions of the 13th and 14th centuries, and a statue from Sungai Langsat representing a male standing on a corpse lying on a pile of skulls, holding a skull bowl and sacrificial knife, with bulging eyes and a figure—perhaps of Amitābha—in the headdress. Measuring 4.41 metres in height and four tons in weight, the latter is the largest statue ever found in Indonesia. It is conventionally identified as either Bhairava (a form of Śiva) or Mahākāla (its Buddhist ‘counterpart’). As eminent art historian Jan Fontein has noted:

These two deities have so many iconographic characteristics in common that it is often difficult to draw clear distinctions between them. Not only in India but also in Indonesia, the identity of statues of these deities can often not be determined with certainty. This is especially true of statues created during the Majapahit period.... (Fontein 1990: 167; Reichle 2007: 250, n. 25)

A statue of a person holding a skull in the left hand, and a sacrificial knife in the right (Fig. 11.6),



Fig. 11.6 (Left): Mahākāla? (Photo: Oudheidkundige Dienst 10593 [detail])

was found in Bahal II at Padang Lawas, the ruin where the Hevajra was found (Schnitger 1937a: 27). Scholars such as Reichle (2007: 154) and Bosch (1930b: 143, plate 42b) have identified the figure as a female, but Bautze-Picron (2014: 10) points out that it is most likely another image of Mahākāla (viewers may have been deceived by the image’s rather rotund physique).<sup>6</sup>

Two famous stone statues of Amoghapāśa were carved in Indonesia. One is found at Candi Jago, a 13th-century Buddhist site in East Java; the other statue was sent by King Kṛtanagara of Sinhasāri to Malayu in the 13th century. The meaning of this act is disputed: it may have been a claim to suzerainty, or a means of solidifying an alliance against the aggressive designs of the Mongols. This statue bears an inscription on its back which gives the date Śaka 1208 (AD 1286) and says that the statue ‘was brought from the Land of Java to Suvarṇabūmi, and erected at Dharmasraya as a gift’. The inscription also mentions the name of Malayu’s king at that time. The implication is that Dharmasraya, located in the highlands of central Sumatra, was the capital of the kingdom. It is likely that the centre of power had moved here, far into the highlands.

6. Bautze-Picron (2014) argues that most, if not all, the so-called ‘Bhairavas’ recovered from Buddhist contexts of Sumatra and Java actually represent frightful (*krodha*) forms of Buddhist deities, such as Mahākāla, Heruka, or Hevajra.



The reasons for this move are disputed, but it seems that the Padang Roco area was heir to the Buddhist culture of Muara Jambi. A Prajñāpāramitā statue in late 13th-century style found at Muara Jambi indicates that the site might not have been entirely abandoned, but few imported ceramics of that period have been discovered at Muara Jambi, whereas samples of them have been found in the Padang Roco region.

Three foundations of brick sanctuaries were found at Padang Roco and restored in the early 1990s (Teguh Hidayat and Yusfa Hendra 2006). The largest measures 21 x 21 metres, and was extended after its original construction. A *makara* has been found at Candi Bukik Awang Maombiak, across the river from Candi Pulau Sawah. Two sanctuaries have been excavated, but were badly damaged. At least seven more are suspected to exist. Bricks from the site have been reused for Islamic graves and looters (Marsis Sutopo 1992). Imported ceramics from the vicinity date from the Song period (11th to 13th centuries).

The Pulau Sawah site has yielded the best evidence for the Buddhist nature of the activities conducted in this region. The evidence consists of a fragment of a stone inscribed with a Sanskrit stanza from a Buddhist text, the *Suvarṇabhāsottamasūtra*: ‘And by this good deed may I soon become a Buddha in the world. May I teach the Dharma for the benefit of the world. May I release creatures tortured by many sufferings’. The script dates from the 9th or 10th century AD (Griffiths 2011: 169). The object is small and so could have been brought to the site at any time after its composition, but it strengthens the conclusion that the site had already become a prominent centre of Buddhist activity before the large Amoghapāśa and Mahākāla statues were erected there.

#### SMALLER SITES OF ESOTERIC BUDDHISM IN THE SUMATRAN HINTERLAND

##### *Muara Takus*

The remains at this site, lying on the upper Kampar River, consist of a complex of brick structures. The major feature is a large *stūpa*-form temple called Candi Mahligai (Fig. 11.7), the date of which



Fig. 11.7: The Mahligai *stūpa*. (Photo: author)

is conjectural: estimates range between the 8th to 9th centuries (Krom 1931: 133) and the 12th to 14th centuries (Bernet Kempers 1959: 69). The outer layer of the structure envelopes an earlier building with a different profile which can only be glimpsed through a small opening in the base. The style of the *stūpa* has been compared to one in Villagaam, Sri Lanka (Groeneveldt 1879: 219). The best depiction of the ruins in their original state (i.e., before restoration) is found in Ijzerman 1893.

The site lies in a remote locale of central Sumatra; there is no evidence that a large population ever lived in the area. It has been suggested that the site was in use for only a short time (Bronson et al. 1973: 16, 45). J.L. Moens (1937) once suggested that Muara Takus was the centre of Śrīvijaya, but this hypothesis has not been generally accepted. Legend connects the construction of the temples with Ādityavarman, and suggests that he acquired power over Kampar by marrying his daughter to the local chief (Ijzerman 1893: 51; Schnitger 1940:

399–401). Muara Takus may have been in some way linked to Padang Lawas, hundred kilometres to the north, via Pasir Pengarajan and Hokan; in support of this are small finds at Manggis and Kotanopan-Pinarik, and a legend of a Batak attack on the site (Schnitger 1936: 40).

A set of eleven inscribed gold plates found in one of the ruins has been assigned on palaeographic grounds to the 12th century (Krom 1930: 149). The last plate bears diagrams including a lotus beneath a *cakra* with eight rims or a sun, a moon, an elephant-goat (*aṅkuśa*), and a trident (*triśūla*). J.G. de Casparis (1956: 48) identified the text as a Sanskrit treatise on Dependent Origination. Several different inscribers worked on it, but the style of script is uniform. He dated it much earlier than Krom: between 650 and 800. The text on the large plates begins with the *Pratītyasamutpādasūtra*, which is also found inscribed on bricks at Nālandā. The plates give a detailed commentary on the sutra, termed *Vibhaṅga* ('division, analysis into sets of categories'), which has also been found on two bricks discovered at Nālandā. *Vibhaṅga* is also preserved in a Chinese translation made by Xuanzhang, dated 661.

This text has an unusual list of the three Thirsts (*tṛṣṇa*), which according to de Casparis is probably an older stage of speculation than the known existing ones. The text follows the *Sarvāstivādin* point of view, whereas the Nālandā version gives a different division of *tṛṣṇa*. Some other minor points also suggest an association of this Indonesian text with the Sarvāstivādins. No Mahāyāna influence is discernible in the Indonesian version; the variations found in the Nālandā version are due to Mahāyāna influence. These plates have some significant differences from those at Nālandā, so cannot be seen as directly influenced from that cosmopolitan centre of Buddhism.

Schnitger (1937b) found a gold disc in the upper part of one of the temples at the site which is unique in that it records the names of Buddhist priests who supervised the construction, and says that the temple was built by Vajradharas (Ślaczka 2007: 364–65).

Another plate found in the Bungsu temple bears an inscription in Nāgarī which Bosch compared to another found at Aek Sangkilon (Schnitger



Fig. 11.8: Stone with Nāgarī letters. (Photo: Kern Institute collection, Leiden University Library, GD 13 1321)

1937a: 11; Ślaczka 2007: 363–64). In this example we have more contextual information than usual: it was found together with fragments of gold leaf, soil, and ash, inside a lotus-shaped base, supported by a 36-sided base which itself was supported by a 20-sided base. The plate bears engraved *vajras*<sup>7</sup> and three Nāgarī letters. A stone with nine Nāgarī letters and *vajras* (Fig. 11.8) was also found nearby (on which, see Griffiths 2014: 236 and, for a revised reading and interpretation, Kandahjaya, this volume, n. 61). Similar inscribed objects (bricks) are reproduced here as Figs. 11.9–11.

### Tanjung Medan

This site is located approximately 75 kilometres northwest of Muara Takus. In 1876 a *stūpa*-form structure still stood here, but in 1930 only brick heaps remained. A gold plate and a *kendi* (water goblet) with neck of gold and rim of silver have been reclaimed from the rubble. The plate bore a *maṇḍala* of eight Bodhisattvas and an inscription

7. As argued by Griffiths (2014), what Ijzerman described as 'triśūlas' (i.e., tridents, which are Śaiva symbols) are in fact *vajras* (or *viśvavajras*), i.e. eminently (Esoteric) Buddhist symbols.



Figs. 11.9–11 (top to bottom): Inscribed bricks. (Photo: author)

of Buddhist formulae in Nāgarī script, which cannot be older than the 12th century (Bosch 1930: 133; Schnitger 1937a: 14; Bronson et al. 1973: 59). It is difficult to date the remaining fragments of the temples, six of which are found spread over an area of 18,000 square metres. Temples I, II, and VI have been restored, while the others are too fragmentary to reconstruct. Temple VI may be the gateway to the site.

### Kota Cina

With this site we return to the coastal zone. Kota Cina is now seven kilometres inland from the coast, and only about 1.5 metres above sea level. When it was occupied the site may have been much nearer the Strait of Melaka; deposition of silt seems to have been rapid during the last few centuries. Remains include at least three complexes of brick ruins, statuary, bone, stone, glass, artefacts of gold, bronze, and iron, and remains of tree resins (dammar), an article of trade associated with Sumatra during the classical period. Edwards McKinnon also recovered about a ton of potsherds, of which about two-thirds are earthenware, most probably made locally, and the remaining one-third imported porcelain and stoneware, mostly of Chinese manufacture (Miksic 1979; Edwards McKinnon 1984).

Evidence from dated Chinese and Sinhalese coins, Chinese porcelain, statuary, and radiocarbon dates all support the conclusion that the site was occupied in the late 11th and late 13th centuries. Villagers in Kota Cina have found two granite Buddha statues, one of which is very similar to a South Indian image of the 13th century, while the other appears more closely related to Sri Lanka. One intact lingam of polished granite and a fragment of another, and statues of Viṣṇu and Lakṣmī indicate that the people of Kota Cina may have belonged to two religious communities. (It is also possible that they belonged to slightly different time periods). Numerous porcelain and stoneware fragments indicate that the population carried on a thriving commerce with China.

The Buddhist remains from Kota Cina, principally the two granite statues, display no esoteric traits. They appear more closely related to the Theravāda aesthetic which was sweeping into the central part of the Siamo-Malay Peninsula, at the border between the Malay and Siamese ethno-linguistic groups. It seems that this busy trading community espoused a type of Buddhism which was not part of the esoteric tradition. This suggests that it was inhabited mainly by foreigners and by locals who were neither Hindu nor Buddhist. No historical documents have yet emerged to enable us to link it with any polity known in any sources, foreign or indigenous.



## CONSECRATION DEPOSITS

Many of the sites discussed here have yielded small inscribed objects, including gold, brick, and stone. This phenomenon is not limited to Sumatra; numerous other examples have been noted in other parts of Southeast Asia. The largest and possibly most complete set was recovered from Gumpung Temple in Muara Jambi, but even there many elements of the set were no doubt lost. A study of this type of archaeological data by Anna A. Ślaczka (2007) has added significantly to our understanding of them by reference to a South Indian text on architecture and ritual, the *Kāśyapaśilpa*. It was probably written in the 11th or 12th century. According to Ślaczka's data, there is much more archaeological information available for this type of artefact in Southeast Asia than exists in India. She found only about fifteen examples where archaeological data on the practice of making consecration deposits exists in India, whereas there are about 200 such reports from Southeast Asia (ibid.: 1). It is not possible to explain this discrepancy, but this situation makes it possible to add significantly to the comparative data which enables us to study the relationships between the two regions. One interesting feature is that the *Kāśyapaśilpa* is written to guide the builders of a Hindu temple, whereas most of the sites where such deposits have been found in Southeast Asia are Buddhist.

The *Kāśyapaśilpa* gives instructions for three ceremonies during the process of constructing a temple. These are: *prathameṣṭakā-nyāsa*, 'the placing of the first bricks', *mūrdheṣṭakā-nyāsa*, 'the placing of the crowning bricks', and *garbha-nyāsa*, 'the placing of the embryo' (ibid.: 5). In Southeast Asian archaeology, early discoverers of such deposits tended to call them 'relics', under the assumption that they contained ashes of cremated humans, and that the temples were funerary monuments. Thus, the containers were called 'reliquaries'. This assumption still can be found in many texts, but the Javanese archaeologist R. Soekmono (1975, 1995) has thoroughly disproved this notion. Thus, Ślaczka proposes the term 'consecration deposits' for this category of material.

In the first phase of construction, the description of the ceremony of placing the first bricks in

the *Kāśyapaśilpa* gives instructions for digging the foundation pit. When conducting the ceremony of *kumbha-* or *kalaśasthāpana*, 'the placing of the jars', the text specifies that: 'Then one should make *karāla*<sup>8</sup> and so on in order to fix (the finial) firmly' (Ślaczka 2007: 171). The excavated pit is filled up with gravel (ibid.: 173). These passages may help to clarify a phenomenon which is found at several temples in Sumatra and Java. At Muara Jambi, Kedaton was found to have had its base filled with huge quantities of white quartz pebbles several centimetres in diameter. At Sungai Langsat, a temple was found to have been built on a layer of andesite cobbles mixed with kaolinite (Marsis Sutopo 1992). A similar layer of white gravel was discovered beneath Puntadewa on the Dieng Plateau in Central Java. It seems highly probable that this practice derives from a ritual prescription similar to that found in the *Kāśyapaśilpa*.

The consecration deposit container (*garbha-bhājana*, *phelā*) should be constructed of metal (Ślaczka 2007: 177). In Gumpung, it seems that the containers were in fact made of lead. The text gives directions for placing mantras and vowels (*svara*) in the compartments of the casket (ibid.). Also placed in the deposit container are various metals, semi-precious stones, attributes of the main deity, and grains. The location for the *garbha* is near the door to the temple. In Kedah, at site 15, a deposit was in fact found to the right of the door. In some North Indian texts, however, the *garbha* is placed in the centre (ibid.: 210, n. 41). In Vaiṣṇava texts, a tortoise is often accompanied by other attributes such as the conch shell, the discus, the club, and Garuḍa (ibid.: 226, n. 20).

Ślaczka compiled an exhaustive list of consecration deposits (or what may well have been such deposits) at Southeast Asian sites. It seems that none of them precisely follows the *Kāśyapaśilpa* instructions, but elements of the same type of ritual practice can almost always be discerned.

## THE 14TH CENTURY

This chapter has omitted the 14th century, not because it is unimportant, but because it is so

8. A type of coating or mortar; according to *Māyāmata* 18.93, however, *karāla* is 'gravel stones the size of *abhaya* or *akṣa* fruits' (Dagens 1994: 275).



complex that it would take another chapter to discuss it, and because little archaeological data for that century is yet available. There are many inscriptions from this time, but their translations are still beset with many uncertainties. Most of the information for the 14th century comes from the highlands, specifically the area of Padang Roco, but more significantly from another region further north, the Tanahdatar region. That area and period are of great interest because of deviations displayed by the Buddhism there and then from the Buddhism which had existed in Sumatra in the previous 600 years rather than continuity with the past.

### CONCLUSION

Sumatran Buddhism was definitely a local product, not a mere reflection of foreign beliefs, though Sumatrans were definitely rapidly apprised of new artistic and philosophical ideas from the Buddhist realm which covered South Asia, Central Asia, East Asia, and Southeast Asia.<sup>9</sup> In the year AD 1000, these regions covered about half of the urbanized, literate areas of the entire globe. The history of this enormous area can only be understood by examining the similarities and differences between them in their interpretations of religious doctrines. The statement by Arlo Griffiths (2011: 172) that ‘while political or economic history may not stand to gain much from further discoveries, it is especially our perspective on the history of Buddhist institutions and practices in Sumatra, which stands to become significantly enriched as new discoveries become known to scholarship’ is much too humble. As Woodward has indicated, Buddhist ideas were at least excellent proxies for the political and social ideology of the societies where they were espoused, and more likely they were an independent variable shaping the possibilities of the political sphere rather than reacting to them.

The frequency with which *vajras* and *viśvavajras* appear in two- and three-dimensional forms in the archaeological record of Sumatra seems without precedent in archaeology in South Asia. This fascination with the *vajra* implies two characteristics about Sumatran Buddhism: its esoteric aspects were extremely popular in ritual; and the local Buddhism, like other Sumatran appropriations of cultural materials from South Asia, made use of certain motifs from South Asian art, but placed very different emphases on some of them. Sumatra was not an isolated backwater; even the people in the highlands (where the majority of Esoteric Buddhist sites are found) for most of the Buddhist period were well aware of developments in the Buddhist cosmopolitan world, as witnessed by the use of Nāgarī script for Sanskrit mantras and *yantras* engraved on stone, metal foils, and bricks.

The extraordinary complexity of the temple construction rituals discussed by Ślaczka hints at the level of detail which could have been recovered had the consecration deposits in the 200 sites in Southeast Asia where they appear been properly recorded. In fact none of them can be reconstructed in its entirety. This situation is due to numerous factors, but one which could have been avoided is the use of technicians to dismantle temples for restoration rather than allocating the job to archaeologists. There are still sites in Muara Jambi which have not been restored, Mahligai Temple being the most important. This site lies at the northwest corner of the site, and appears to have great potential to yield relatively intact consecration deposits. Using the insights of Ślaczka’s research as a guide, and employing Davidson’s and Woodward’s depiction of the link between *maṇḍalas* and political ideology, it is still possible for Buddhist archaeology in Sumatra to reach a much higher level of precision, and thus insight into Sumatra’s role as a source of Buddhist ideas as well as art.

9. While acknowledging the importance of the Pāla intellectual world in shaping the Buddhist cultures of the Malay Peninsula and the Khmer domains, Skilling (2007: 97) points out that ‘[t]he icons and architecture of the region are accomplished and distinctive—they are not mere copies of Pāla or other Indian forms. That is, the members of local cultures were active participants who responded to normative texts according to their own social and religious needs and their own aesthetic ideals’.

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